The Dry Spell: Why Their Careers Are Stalling

Volume 07 — locked in. As of **April 28, 2006**, every fictional actor except Marc-Anthony is stuck: famous or acclaimed, and still unable to get steady acting work. Each stall comes from a **mix of real 2006 industry forces, personal obstacles and plain bad luck**, so no two are alike. The MCU is what eventually breaks every one of them out.

> **A key 2006 date:** the TV networks announce their fall schedules to advertisers at the **"upfronts," May 15-18, 2006**. Several characters have pilots waiting on that week. Most won't survive it.

Marc-Anthony Bullock — Age 24 — Tony Stark / Iron Man

His only problem: growing out of the child-star image. Marc isn't unlucky and his talent isn't in doubt. Audiences and casting directors still see the beloved characters he played on the Donohue Channel and Nickelodeon. Fans shout his old catchphrases at him in airports. Executives say "we love him, but can people see him as a man?"

- **He loves those characters 100%** and refuses to trash them in interviews to look edgier, the way many former child stars do. He says, *"Those kids raised me. I'm not burning the house down to prove I moved out."* His gratitude is genuine, and the industry misreads it as being stuck.
- So his challenge isn't finding work. It's being seen as more than the boy everyone fell in love with: the same doubt that hangs over his *Iron Man* candidacy.

What breaks the curse: Tony Stark. Marc proves he can play a grown man without ever disowning the kid.

Amond Baker — Age 24 — Bruce Banner / Hulk

Well known, beloved and funny, and almost nobody will hire him for anything else.

- **Typecast as the funny best friend.** After ten years as the comic sidekick on kids' TV, casting directors laugh before he even reads. Dramatic auditions end with "Can you make it funnier?"
- **Cut out of his breakthrough.** In 2004 he gave a devastating dramatic supporting performance in a prestige film. The studio cut the film's running time for release and his entire role ended up on the cutting-room floor. It now exists only as a DVD deleted scene.
- **He turns down the stereotype roles.** The other parts offered to young Black actors in 2006 are thugs, drug dealers and the friend who dies first. Amond says no every time. His integrity is costing him a living.
- **Agency shake-up:** his agent left in a 2005 agency merger and the new team quietly let him go.

The last straw: Two pilots this season, a comedy and a drama. The comedy wants him only if he plays the sidekick again. The drama's network passes in May.

What breaks the curse: Bruce Banner: a tragic, haunted, serious role that the Hulk can't make funny.

Tyrese Avery — Age 24 — Steve Rogers / Captain America

One of the biggest pop stars on Earth, and a punchline as an actor.

- **The vanity-project flop.** His 2004 starring film, a glossy musical romance built around his album, flopped and earned him a Razzie nomination. Critics wrote “Stick to singing.” The stain sticks.
- **His record label blocks him.** His contract with **Firefly Records**, which is owned by Donohue, requires world tours on fixed dates. The label won't release him for the 4-6 month film shoots, and it makes far more money from his tours than from his movies.
- **Insurance companies won't cover him.** The companies that insure film productions see a touring superstar who is constantly mobbed as a scheduling and safety risk. Without insurance, a film can't get financing.
- **He's seen as stunt casting.** Serious directors assume he's only there to sell soundtracks.

The last straw: A respected director wanted him for a small dramatic role, but the label refused to move a single tour date and the role went to someone else.

What breaks the curse: Captain America: a role about humility and duty, earned through auditions, not fame. He fights his own label to take it.

Esther Smilley — Age 23 — Thor

A household name and America's sweetheart, and she has been offered almost nothing new in two years.

- **She's shut out of half of Hollywood by her own family.** The Smilleys refuse to work on anything Donohue produces, finances or distributes, and in 2006 that is nearly half of all major projects.
- **Her parents' contract terms scare producers away.** Smilley Management Group demands script approval, wardrobe approval, no kissing scenes, and the right to approve her co-stars. Studios walk away.
- **Family films are drying up.** The live-action family-film market is shrinking, and the musicals and faith films her parents approve are rare.
- **Producers assume she'll say no.** Directors with adult roles don't even send them, assuming her parents will refuse. And she never sees the scripts that do arrive, because her parents screen them.

The last straw: She learns secretly, from Simone, that a celebrated director offered her a complex adult role in 2005 and her father turned it down without telling her.

What breaks the curse: Thor: a warrior, a god and a grown woman. It's the first role she takes against her parents' wishes.

Arianna Cummings — Age 23 — Claire Barton / Hawkeye

Critics call her the best actress of her generation that nobody has heard of.

- **Her name doesn't sell.** Independent films are financed by pre-selling them to foreign distributors, and those buyers want famous names. She keeps getting replaced at the financing stage.
- **She's always the runner-up.** She has made it to the final screen test for four big roles. All four went to bigger names.
- **Her best film is stuck in limbo.** Her acclaimed 2005 festival film was bought by a distributor that went bankrupt, and it now sits in legal limbo with nobody able to release it.
- **Colorism.** She is a dark-skinned Black woman in 2006 Hollywood, which still too often casts lighter-skinned actresses as leads and love interests. She knows it, her agents know it, and nobody says it out loud.

The last straw: Her fourth near-miss: a casting director told her she was the best audition of the year, and the studio cast a pop singer instead.

What breaks the curse: Claire Barton, a role that has nothing to do with being a love interest and everything to do with being the best at what she does.

Harmony Divine — Age 23 — Natasha Romanoff / Black Widow

Famous on Broadway and unknown in Hollywood, and now she's stuck between the two.

- **Seen as “just a dancer.”** Film and TV casting offers her dance movies and nothing else, no matter how strong her acting reels are.
- **The injury.** In late 2005 she tore a ligament in her knee (her ACL) during a performance. Her Broadway show replaced her and then closed early. She can't dance during rehab, so even the dance-movie offers stopped.
- **She's on the wrong coast.** She lives in New York, and most TV pilots and films are cast in Los Angeles during the winter pilot season. She can't afford to move while she's in rehab.
- **Union red tape:** her stage-actors' union work doesn't count toward screen-actors' union health insurance, so she's close to losing her coverage.

The last straw: She auditions on crutches for a dramatic pilot and lands it. The network passes on the show in May.

What breaks the curse: Black Widow: a role that uses every bit of her dance discipline, physical control and acting.

Tyler Chapman — Age 24 — Bucky Barnes / Winter Soldier

A respected actor and musician with an unfair label: “difficult.”

- **Canceled on a cliffhanger.** The acclaimed cable drama he co-starred in was canceled in 2005 after one season, ending on an unresolved cliffhanger.
- **The “difficult” label.** On that show he stood up for a production assistant a producer was abusing. The producer has been quietly calling him “difficult” to people around town ever since. In Hollywood, that one word is a death sentence.
- **Band commitments:** his indie band's tours lock up his schedule, and casting directors assume he isn't serious about acting.

The last straw: A guest-star role is withdrawn the day before shooting. His agent hears the same producer made a phone call.

What breaks the curse: Bucky Barnes, a loyal soldier haunted by things done to him, a role directors trust him with after one meeting.

David Tipton — Age 25 — Hank Pym / Ant-Man

Everybody knows his face and nobody knows his name, and right now he can barely pay rent.

- **Typecast:** he plays the nerd, the lab tech or the hacker, with one line each. He looks too young to play a doctor and too old to play a student.
- **Robbed by his manager.** In 2005 he discovered his manager had been stealing his residual checks for three years. The manager disappeared, and David is broke. He can't afford new headshots, acting classes or a decent agent.
- **Bad luck:** two shows he booked recurring roles on were canceled before they ever aired.

The last straw: He takes a day job at an electronics store and is recognized by a customer who can't place him: “Weren't you the guy who fixed the computer in that thing?”

What breaks the curse: Hank Pym, the genius he has been playing in the background for years, finally as the lead.

Tayia Boyd — Age 24 — Pepper Potts

A kid-network star whose show ended, and the network kept her on hold until it was too late.

- **The holding deal.** When her series ended, the network kept her under an exclusive option for two more years, paying her not to work elsewhere while it searched for a spinoff that never came. By the time the option expired in 2004, her moment had passed.
- **Kid-show stigma:** prestige casting directors still see a tween sitcom star.
- **Seen as Marc's sidekick.** The press defines her as “Marc-Anthony's co-star,” never as a lead in her own right.
- **Bad luck:** two indie films she was set to lead fell apart when their financing collapsed weeks before shooting.

The last straw: A third film's financing collapses a week before shooting. She considers quitting acting.

What breaks the curse: Pepper Potts: smart, capable and grown up. Her chemistry with Marc is no longer a sidekick dynamic but a partnership.

Elxa Bullock — Age 25 — Janet van Dyne / Wasp

An award-winning actress whose family is too powerful for anyone to hire her.

- **Natasha's 2005 rule.** After a 2005 shareholder lawsuit accused the company of nepotism, at the same time regulators were scrutinizing Donohue, Natasha banned family members from new Donohue productions. Donohue owns half the industry, so that rule alone halves Elxa's options.
- **Rival studios won't touch her.** Some fear she's a Donohue spy. Others are aligned with the Smilleys. Most are terrified that if they fire her, give her a bad review or cut her scenes, they'll offend Natasha Bullock.
- **Her TV-host work hurts her acting reputation.** She hosts a talk show on a non-Donohue network, and critics treat that as proof she's a personality, not an actress.

The last straw: A director tells her privately: “You're the best actress I saw this year. I can't risk you.”

What breaks the curse: Janet van Dyne. *Ant-Man* (2009) is a Marvel film, not a Donohue production, so the family rule doesn't apply, and she earns the role at audition.

Grace Bullock — Age 12 — Wanda Maximoff / Scarlet Witch

A gifted child actress and singer caught by the same family rule.

- **The 2005 rule ended her show.** Her Donohue Channel series was quietly canceled after one season when Natasha's no-family policy took effect.
- **Rival kids' networks won't cast a Donohue.** They fear it would look like they're helping the competition.
- **The awkward age.** At 12 she's in the transition years when child actors are too old for little-kid roles and too young for teen roles.

The last straw: She sings at a charity event and the video goes around the early internet. No network will touch her.

What breaks the curse: Wanda Maximoff, by 2015, at age 21: a role built on power, grief and family. Her big brother is in the same universe.

Elijah Blackman — Age 12 — Pietro Maximoff / Quicksilver

A working child actor with talent and no breaks.

- **The “18 to play younger” problem.** California's child-labor laws limit how many hours minors can work on set, so producers often cast 18-year-olds to play younger kids.
- **Money and distance:** his family lives in Atlanta and can't afford to move to Los Angeles for pilot season.
- **Bad luck:** he booked a series regular role on a kids' network pilot, and it wasn't picked up.

The last straw: His mother takes a second job to fly him to LA for one audition, and the role is cut from the script before he gets there.

What breaks the curse: Pietro Maximoff, by 2015, at age 21: a fast, cocky, protective twin brother.

Note: the Smilley family's own career stalls (Desmond, Julian and Simone) are covered in Volume 05.